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# Crime Fiction Toolkit

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*Eight sections covering the craft mechanics that separate published crime fiction from the manuscripts that never make it. Built from real-world experience as a retired law enforcement officer, #1 Amazon author, and television writer.*

Jeff Bonilla - The Writers Precinct - 2026

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## SECTION 01

## Tropes That Work & Tropes That Don't

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*Tropes are not cliches -- they are genre contracts. Readers pick up crime fiction expecting certain promises. The craft is knowing which promises to keep, which to subvert, and which to retire entirely.*

### TROPES THAT WORK

#### -> The Reluctant Detective

A protagonist who doesn't want the case but can't walk away. Works because it creates internal conflict that mirrors the external plot. The key: the reluctance must cost them something real -- a relationship, a job, their peace of mind.

#### -> The Crime That's Bigger Than It Looks

A seemingly routine case that unravels into something much larger. Readers love the escalation. Make sure the early crime genuinely foreshadows the larger one.

#### -> The Unreliable Witness

Someone who saw something but can't be fully trusted. Effective when the unreliability comes from psychology, not plot convenience -- addiction, trauma, self-interest.

#### -> Ticking Clock

Someone will die or evidence will disappear unless the protagonist acts. Works in every subgenre. Just make sure the clock is credible and the stakes are personal.

#### -> The Mentor Figure With Secrets

An experienced cop or investigator who guides the protagonist -- but is hiding something. Readers expect it. Use it anyway, but make the secret worth the wait.

### TROPES THAT DON'T (OR REQUIRE SURGERY)

#### X The Brilliant Detective Who Explains Everything at the End

Works in Agatha Christie. In contemporary crime fiction it reads as condescending. Distribute the revelation across the last act instead of dumping it in one scene.

#### X The Female Victim Who Exists Only to Motivate the Male Protagonist

Readers clock this immediately. If your inciting crime involves a woman, give her a life, a voice, a perspective -- even posthumously.

#### X The Evil for Evil's Sake Villain

Real criminals have logic. Even the most horrific offenders have a worldview that makes sense to them. A villain with no coherent motivation is a plot device, not a character.

#### X Twists That Require the Protagonist to Be Stupid

If your big reveal only works because your detective missed an obvious clue for 200 pages, the reader will feel cheated. Make the clue genuinely difficult to see, not just ignored.

**The subversion rule:** You can use any trope if you acknowledge it and complicate it. The reader knows what a reluctant detective is. Give them one with a reason they haven't seen before.

## SECTION 02

## Story Structure for Crime Thrillers

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*Crime fiction has a structural DNA that differs from romance, sci-fi, and literary fiction. The inciting crime is not your Act One break -- it's often your opening. Everything that follows is the unraveling.*

### THE CRIME (Pages 1-15)

Establish what happened and why the reader should care. This is not backstory -- it is a wound that needs closing. The crime should feel personal to someone, even if the protagonist doesn't know it yet.

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### THE HOOK INTO THE INVESTIGATION (Pages 15-30)

Your protagonist enters. Their entry must cost them something. Reluctance here is structural, not stylistic. The reader needs to feel the weight of what your protagonist is stepping into.

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### EARLY INVESTIGATION -- FALSE LEADS (Pages 30-90)

Your protagonist pursues the obvious answer. It's wrong. Every lead should reveal something true about the world even when it's a dead end. False leads that teach us nothing are pacing killers.

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### MIDPOINT REVERSAL (Pages 90-120)

Something flips. Either what they thought they knew is wrong, or the stakes escalate dramatically, or the protagonist is personally implicated. The best midpoints do all three.

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### DARK NIGHT / LOWEST POINT (Pages 200-240)

The protagonist has lost. Evidence is gone, the suspect walked, a source is dead. This must be earned -- you can't manufacture this moment without the preceding losses being real.

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### THE BREAK (Pages 240-270)

A detail they missed. A connection that finally fires. Something the reader was given earlier that now snaps into place. Plant this in Act One. Find it in Act Three.

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### RESOLUTION AND COST (Pages 270-300)

The crime is solved or closed. But the protagonist is not the same. Crime fiction that ends without cost reads as hollow. Something must have changed -- in them, in their world.

**Series note:** If you're writing a series, the resolution of the crime is the plot ending -- but the character arc must remain open enough to carry into the next book. Solve the case. Don't solve the person.

## SECTION 03

## POV Guide

*Point of view is not a stylistic choice in crime fiction -- it is a structural one. What your reader knows, and when they know it, determines whether you're writing a mystery, a thriller, or a procedural.*

| POV                              | BEST FOR                                                                               | WATCH OUT FOR                                                                              |
|----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>First Person (I)</b>          | Hard-boiled, PI fiction, personal thrillers. Creates intimacy and limited information. | Reader only knows what your protagonist knows. Easy to accidentally slip into other heads. |
| <b>Third Limited</b>             | Procedurals, ensemble cast, multiple plot lines. Most flexible choice.                 | Distance can creep in. Stay inside your POV character's head or you're writing omniscient. |
| <b>Third Omniscient</b>          | Literary crime, complex moral landscapes, multiple antagonists.                        | Extremely difficult to execute. Most attempts become unintentional head-hopping.           |
| <b>Dual POV (Protag + Antag)</b> | Thrillers, serial killer fiction, cat-and-mouse narratives.                            | Antagonist chapters must be as compelling as protagonist chapters. Most aren't.            |

### WHAT CRIME READERS EXPECT

Crime readers are pattern-literate. They notice POV violations immediately -- even if they couldn't name what broke.

- > If you open in first person, stay there. Switching to third mid-series is jarring.
- > Head-hopping -- switching POV within a scene without a clear break -- is the most common amateur tell in crime manuscripts. Every editor flags it.
- > Villain POV chapters work best when the reader knows who the villain is. Hiding it creates confusion, not tension.
- > If your detective doesn't know something, your reader shouldn't know it either -- unless you're deliberately building dramatic irony.

## SECTION 04

## Genre Conventions

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*Every crime fiction subgenre has a reader contract. Break it intentionally and you're subverting. Break it accidentally and you lose the reader. Know which one you're doing.*

### THE FAIR PLAY MYSTERY

In fair play mysteries, all clues available to the detective must be available to the reader. This is the foundational contract of the genre. If your detective solves the case using information the reader never had, you've broken the contract.

- > Plant every clue the detective uses before the reveal
- > Red herrings are allowed -- but they must play fair too
- > The solution must be surprising but, in retrospect, inevitable

### PROCEDURAL ACCURACY

Readers of police procedurals have a baseline expectation of accuracy. You don't need to get every detail right, but you need to get the feel right -- the rhythm of how investigations actually unfold.

- > Miranda rights are read at arrest, not during questioning -- most TV gets this wrong
- > Chain of custody matters. Evidence handled improperly gets cases thrown out
- > Detectives don't work alone. Partners, supervisors, DAs -- the ecosystem matters
- > Autopsies take time. DNA takes weeks. Rushing these feels false to trained readers

### THE DETECTIVE ARCHETYPE CONTRACT

Your protagonist type signals a contract to the reader before they've read a page.

- > Police detective: institutional, constrained by rules, political pressure from above
- > Private investigator: freelance, morally flexible, often blocked by the police
- > Amateur sleuth: outsider perspective, charm over grit -- readers expect this
- > Legal/medical professional: expertise-driven, ethics-bound, insider access

## SECTION 05

## Common Mistakes Editors Flag

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*These are the craft errors that appear in acquisition rejection letters, editorial notes, and one-star reviews. Most are fixable in revision -- but you have to know what you're looking for.*

### HEAD HOPPING

**The problem:** Moving between character perspectives within the same scene without a clear break. Often the writer doesn't realize they're doing it.

**The fix:** Search every scene for moments where you're inside a character's head who is not your designated POV character. Cut or restructure.

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### INFORMATION DUMPS

**The problem:** Backstory delivered in large blocks, usually in early chapters. Readers stop reading here.

**The fix:** Distribute backstory through action and dialogue. Only deliver it when the reader is desperate to have it.

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### PASSIVE VOICE IN ACTION SEQUENCES

**The problem:** "The gun was fired" instead of "She fired the gun." Passive construction drains tension from exactly the scenes that need it most.

**The fix:** Search for "was" and "were" followed by a verb. Most instances in action sequences should be restructured.

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### ON-THE-NOSE DIALOGUE

**The problem:** Characters saying exactly what they mean, feel, and intend. Real cops, criminals, and lawyers talk around things. Subtext is the engine of crime dialogue.

**The fix:** Read your dialogue aloud. If every line is literal and direct, add subtext: what does this character want that they're not saying?

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### TELEVISION FORENSICS

**The problem:** DNA results in hours. Clean fingerprints from every surface. Facial recognition that identifies anyone instantly. Trained readers disengage immediately.

**The fix:** Use *The Precinct*. This is exactly what it's built for.

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## SECTION 06

## The Twist vs. The Cheat

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*The difference between a twist that earns a gasp and one that earns anger is a single thing: setup. Every legitimate twist was possible to see coming. The reader just didn't see it.*

### WHAT MAKES A TWIST WORK

A legitimate twist has three components:

- > **The clue was there.** Somewhere in the text, the information that makes the twist true was available to the reader. They overlooked it or were directed away from it by a red herring.
- > **The twist recontextualizes what came before.** After the reveal, the reader should be able to look back and see the story differently. The best twists make you want to reread from page one.
- > **The twist is emotionally true.** Even if the reader didn't see it coming, it must feel like something that could have happened given who these characters are.

### WHAT MAKES A CHEAT

A cheat withholds information from the reader that the protagonist had. It introduces a key fact in the final act that has no prior foundation. It requires characters to behave in ways that contradict their established nature. Readers remember a cheat -- and they write about it in reviews.

### THE RETROSPECTIVE TEST

Before submitting, go back through your manuscript with your twist in hand. Ask whether the clues are genuinely present and whether a careful reader could have assembled them. If the answer is no, you're not ready to submit -- you're ready to revise.

**The red herring rule:** A red herring is not a cheat -- it's a craft tool. It must be plausible, seeded with the same care as the real clue, and resolved. A red herring that simply disappears is a plot hole.

## SECTION 07

## Character Archetypes

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*Crime fiction has a cast of recurring roles that readers recognize and expect. Using them is not lazy -- refusing to evolve them is. Know the archetype well enough to know where to break from it.*

### THE DAMAGED DETECTIVE

Alcoholic, divorced, haunted by a past case. This archetype exists because damage creates internal conflict. The problem: it's overused to the point of parody.

**How to use it:** Give the damage a specific origin and a specific current cost. "Drinks too much" is an archetype. "Drinks because he testified against his partner and watched a family fall apart" is a character.

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### THE ANTAGONIST WHO BELIEVES THEY'RE RIGHT

The most compelling villains are not evil -- they are logical. Their actions follow from a worldview that, however distorted, has internal coherence.

**How to use it:** Write your antagonist's justification before you write their crimes. Understand their logic completely, even if you find it repellent.

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### THE PARTNER

Foil, conscience, comic relief, or second set of eyes. The partner exists to give your protagonist someone to talk to without resorting to internal monologue.

**How to use it:** Give the partner their own agenda. If they exist only to serve the protagonist's story, they're a prop, not a character.

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### THE WITNESS WHO KNOWS MORE THAN THEY'RE SAYING

A staple because it mirrors how investigations actually work. Real witnesses lie, omit, protect, and misremember.

**How to use it:** Establish why they're withholding before the reveal. The withheld information should be something the reader can understand wanting to hide.

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### THE INSTITUTIONAL OBSTACLE

The bureaucratic superior, the by-the-book DA, the politician who wants the case closed. Exists to create friction between the protagonist and the truth.

**How to use it:** Don't make them simply obstructionist. Give them a reason -- career protection, genuine belief in process. Pure obstruction is lazy writing.

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## SECTION 08

## Dialogue Rules

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*Crime characters -- cops, criminals, lawyers, forensic specialists -- have professional vocabularies and cultural rhythms that most fiction writers get wrong. Here's how they actually talk on the page.*

### **COPS DON'T OVER-EXPLAIN**

Real law enforcement communication is compressed, acronym-heavy, and assumes shared knowledge. Translate only as much as your POV character would realistically translate. Let the reader work a little.

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### **SUBTEXT IS THE RULE**

Interrogation dialogue is a masterclass in subtext. The detective doesn't say "I know you're lying." They say something that forces the suspect to reveal it. Study real interrogation transcripts. The best fictional interrogations work the same way.

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### **DIALECT AND VERNACULAR: USE IT LIGHTLY**

A character's speech can suggest regional or cultural background without becoming a phonetic exercise. Drop one or two distinctive phrases and let the reader's imagination do the rest. Heavy dialect is exhausting to read.

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### **DIALOGUE TAGS: SIMPLE IS CORRECT**

"Said" is invisible. "Growled," "hissed," "ejaculated" -- these pull the reader out. Use action beats instead of inventive tags. The action contextualizes the line.

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### **EVERYONE TALKS DIFFERENTLY**

A 22-year-old patrol officer and a 55-year-old homicide detective should not sound the same. Read any two characters' dialogue in isolation. If you can't tell who's speaking without the tag, revise.

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### **WHAT'S NOT SAID**

In crime fiction, the most important dialogue is often what characters refuse to say. A suspect who goes silent. A detective who doesn't ask the obvious question. Absence of speech is speech.

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## THE SUITE

## More tools. Same standard.

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The Writers Precinct is a suite of AI-powered research tools built for fiction writers who take authenticity seriously. Each tool is staffed by a character with real-world expertise -- not a generic AI assistant.

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